Northwind Retail - Employee Handbook

This handbook describes the policies and benefits that apply to all full-time and part-time employees of Northwind Retail. It is reviewed annually by People Operations and supersedes all prior versions.

Leave Policy

Full-time employees accrue 18 days of annual paid leave per year, credited at the start of each calendar year in a single lump sum. Part-time employees accrue leave on a pro-rated basis according to their contracted weekly hours. Unused leave up to 5 days may be carried over into the next calendar year; any balance above that is forfeited unless local law requires otherwise.

Sick leave is tracked separately from annual leave and is capped at 10 days per year. Employees returning from more than 3 consecutive sick days must provide a note from a medical practitioner.

Remote Work Policy

Employees may work remotely up to 3 days per week, subject to manager approval and role suitability. Fully remote arrangements, defined as more than 3 remote days per week on an ongoing basis, require VP-level sign-off and are reviewed every 6 months.

Employees working remotely are expected to be reachable during core hours of 10am to 4pm in their local time zone and to attend all scheduled meetings with video enabled where practical.

Expense Reimbursement

Any expense over $50 requires an itemized receipt to be submitted through the expense portal within 30 days of the purchase. Expenses under $50 can be self-certified without a receipt, up to a maximum of $200 in self-certified expenses per quarter.

Historical note: prior to the 2022 policy revision, the receipt threshold for expense reimbursement was set at $75 rather than the current amount, and self-certification did not exist as an option.

Travel booked more than 14 days in advance should use the corporate travel portal; last-minute travel may be booked directly and expensed, subject to the same $50 receipt threshold described above.

Data Security Policy

VPN access is mandatory for any connection to internal systems from outside the office network. Split-tunneling is disabled by default on all company-managed devices. Multi-factor authentication is required for all company accounts, including email, source control, and the expense portal.

Company devices must have full-disk encryption enabled and must not be left unattended and unlocked in public spaces. Any lost or stolen device must be reported to IT Security within 24 hours.

Benefits

Northwind Retail matches employee 401k contributions up to 4 percent of base salary. Health insurance premiums are covered at 80 percent for the employee and 50 percent for dependents. Enrollment windows open once per year in November.

Code of Conduct

Employees are expected to treat colleagues, customers, and vendors with respect. Harassment, discrimination, and retaliation of any kind are grounds for immediate termination, regardless of tenure or role.

Performance Reviews

Formal performance reviews are conducted twice per year, in June and December. Managers are expected to hold informal check-ins with direct reports at least once per month between formal review cycles.

Equipment Policy

New employees are issued a laptop and standard peripherals during onboarding. Equipment refresh requests are evaluated every 3 years, or sooner in the case of hardware failure verified by IT.